

# A Midsummer Night's Dream: A Study Guide

By William Shakespeare



# Meet the Characters

## At Court

### Theseus & Hippolyta

Duke of Athens and Queen of the Amazons — soon to be wed

### The Lovers

**Egeus** — a lord; **Hermia** — his daughter, loves Lysander; **Demetrius** — Egeus's choice; **Helena** — loves Demetrius

## In the Forest

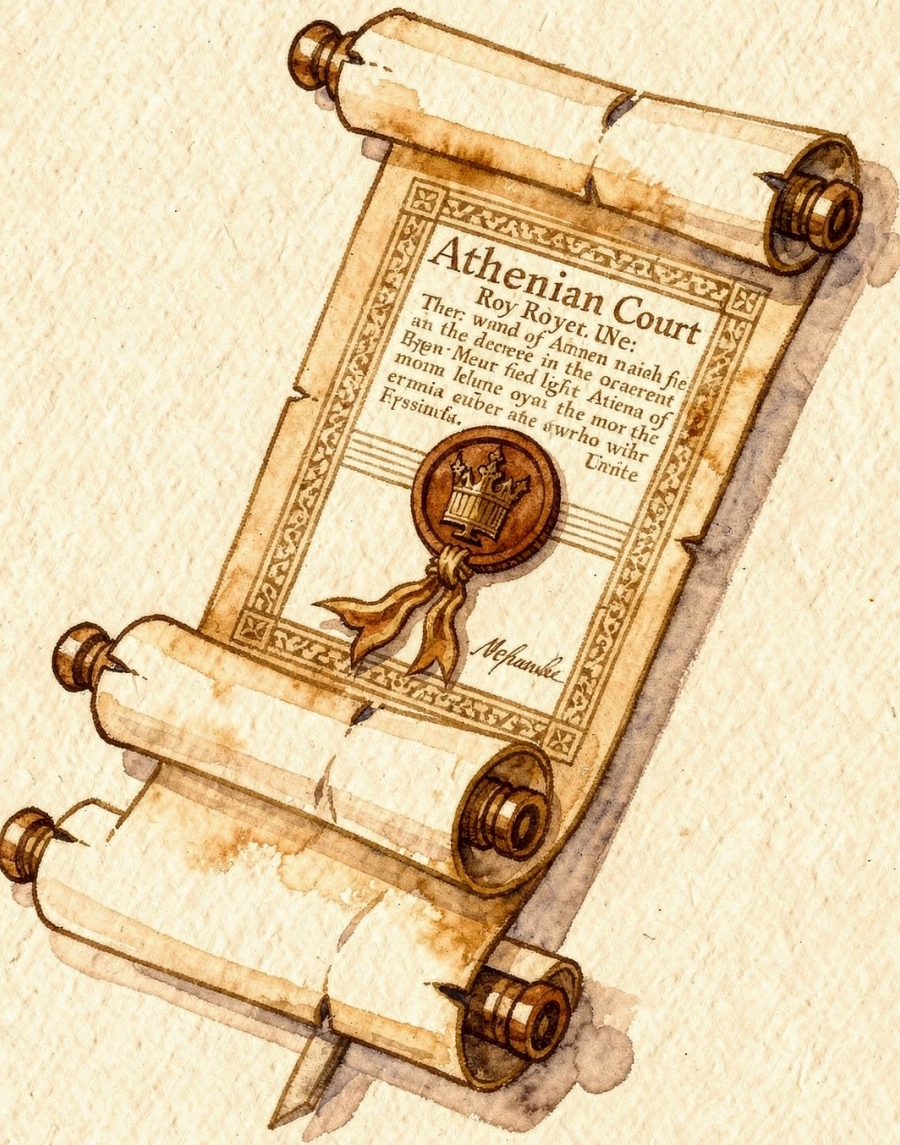
### The Fairy Royals

**Oberon** — King of the Fairies; **Titania** — Queen of the Fairies; **Puck (Robin Goodfellow)** — Oberon's mischievous jester

### The Mechanicals

Working men led by **Peter Quince** and **Nick Bottom**, rehearsing *Pyramus and Thisbe*





# Trouble at Court: The Story Begins

## 1 The Ultimatum

Theseus plans to wed Hippolyta. Egeus demands Hermia marry Demetrius — or face **death or a nunnery**. Hermia refuses, insisting she loves Lysander.

## 2 Into the Forest

Lysander and Hermia plan to elope beyond Athenian law. They confide in Helena — who tells Demetrius, and follows him into the enchanted wood.

# Chaos in the Wood: Puck's Mistake

## 1 Puck's Error

Oberon sends Puck to charm Demetrius's eyes with a magic flower, but Puck anoints Lysander by mistake — both men now love Helena and scorn Hermia.

## 2 Bottom Transformed

Puck gives Bottom a donkey's head; Titania, charmed by the same flower, wakes and falls in love with the ass-headed weaver.





# Awaking to Happiness: Resolution

## 1 Order Restored

Oberon gets the changeling boy, releases Titania from the charm, and restores Lysander's love for Hermia — the couples are happily paired by morning. Theseus overrules Egeus and allows Hermia to marry Lysander.

## 2 Pyramus and Thisbe

The mechanicals perform their unintentionally hilarious tragedy for the newlyweds; fairies bless them all as the night ends.

# Themes & Big Ideas

# Theme 1: Love, Eyes & Enchantment

- Love in the play is visual — centered on the eyes and magic; the enchanted flower makes anyone "madly dote upon the next live creature that it sees"
- Helena asks: does love look "with the eyes, or with the mind"? — the play keeps asking whether love is rational or irrational
- Key quotes: Hermia: "I would my father look'd but with my eyes"; Theseus: "Rather your eyes must with his judgment look"



# Theme 2: Transformation

- Bottom physically transforms (donkey's head) but stays emotionally himself — the most fortunate mortal, embraced by the fairy queen. When Oberon lifts the spell, Titania loathes the sight of the ass-headed Bottom.
- The lovers transform emotionally — Helena betrays her friend; Hermia "turns into a shrew"; when love returns, so does inner peace.





# Theme 3: Reality vs. Imagination

- The mechanicals blur art and life — they fear the audience will believe the lion is real and add a prologue to assure everyone no one actually dies. Quince warns: "An' if you should do it too terribly, you would fright the Duchess and the ladies, that they would shriek..."
- Shakespeare asks: what is real? Fairies, dreams, and theatre all share the same magic — "showing us the magic does not dispel it." All actors are enchanted into the portrayal of their roles.

# The Title: Midsummer + Night + Dream

## Midsummer

The summer solstice: a time of folk festivals, fertility, and holiday indulgence. Associated with "rites of May" and letting go of inhibitions. The apogee of the year's bloom.

## Night

Darkness reveals hidden urges and strange fears. The forest is home to supernaturals, but disorienting for mortals. Nothing is clear at night.

## Dream

The forest experience is a dream for Bottom (pleasure) and a nightmare for the lovers (torment, mockery, betrayal). Love may be a dream, but dreams are quickly-changing psychic flickers.

# Shakespeare's Craft

# Shakespeare & Comedy: How It Works

- Romantic comedy opens with a serious threat (here: a death sentence), tests young lovers, and ends in weddings — "Lord, what fools these mortals be." Parents must block children's desires, and authorities must be unhelpful if true love is to prove itself.
- *A Midsummer Night's Dream*: 9 scenes, 2,174 lines, 80% verse / 20% prose — a tight, lyrical comedy from Shakespeare's "lyrical period" (c. 1594–96), alongside *Romeo and Juliet* and *Richard II*.

# Three Styles of Verse in the Play

## Iambic Pentameter

Blank verse & heroic couplets used by the court. Many critics see this as a spillover from Shakespeare's sonnets. Characters switch between blank verse and couplets — why?

## Ballad Meter (Fourteeners)

Used in Pyramus and Thisbe to give it an "old" medieval sound. Heavy rhyme and alliteration. 14-syllable couplets broken into 8-6-8-6 quatrains.

## Fairy Meter

A quicker 7-syllable trochaic verse for supernatural characters. Example — Titania: "Come, my lord; and in our flight, / Tell me how it came this night..."



# The World of Faerie

# The Origin & Evolution of Fairies

- Medieval fairies were tall, powerful, and dangerous — they could steal children, pinch misbehavers, and ride at night. Even in the Renaissance, fairies were considered real creatures of nearly human size. J.R.R. Tolkien's elves reflect this medieval tradition.
- Shakespeare shrank them: Titania's fairies — Mustardseed, Moth — sport among flowers, delivering dewdrops. Their very names suggest tininess. This "playful alteration" became permanent fashion after 1625.



# ROBIN GOOD-FELLOW, HIS MAD PRANKES AND MERRY IESTS.

Full of honest Mirth, and is a fit Medicine  
for Melancholy.



Printed at London by Thomas Cotes, and are to be sold by  
Francis Grove, at his Shop on Snow-hill, over the  
Saracens-head. 1639

## Robin Goodfellow: Who Is Puck?

Robin Goodfellow was England's "national practical joker" — a large, hairy wandering spirit who loved pranks, swept hearths, and meddled in true love. First written mention (1489) describes him as a prankster famous for his resounding laugh, "ho, ho, ho!" A matchmaker by instinct, he would meddle in any cause of true love.

Shakespeare nicknamed him "Puck," placed him in Oberon's service as his jester, and cost him his independence — "fame has its price." No longer did Robin cavort at will; he had to obey.

# Production History

# Notable Adaptations on Stage & Screen

## 1935 Film

Mickey Rooney as Puck, James Cagney as Bottom; balletic fairies in black and white.

## 1999 Film

Directed by Michael Hoffman; Kevin Kline as Bottom, Michelle Pfeiffer as Titania, Calista Flockhart; saturnalian fairies.

## 1969 RSC Film

Directed by Peter Hall in modern dress (mini skirts, go-go boots); Judi Dench as Titania, Helen Mirren and Diana Rigg as the lovers.

# Production Traditions: Costumes, Lights & Doubling

## Doubling

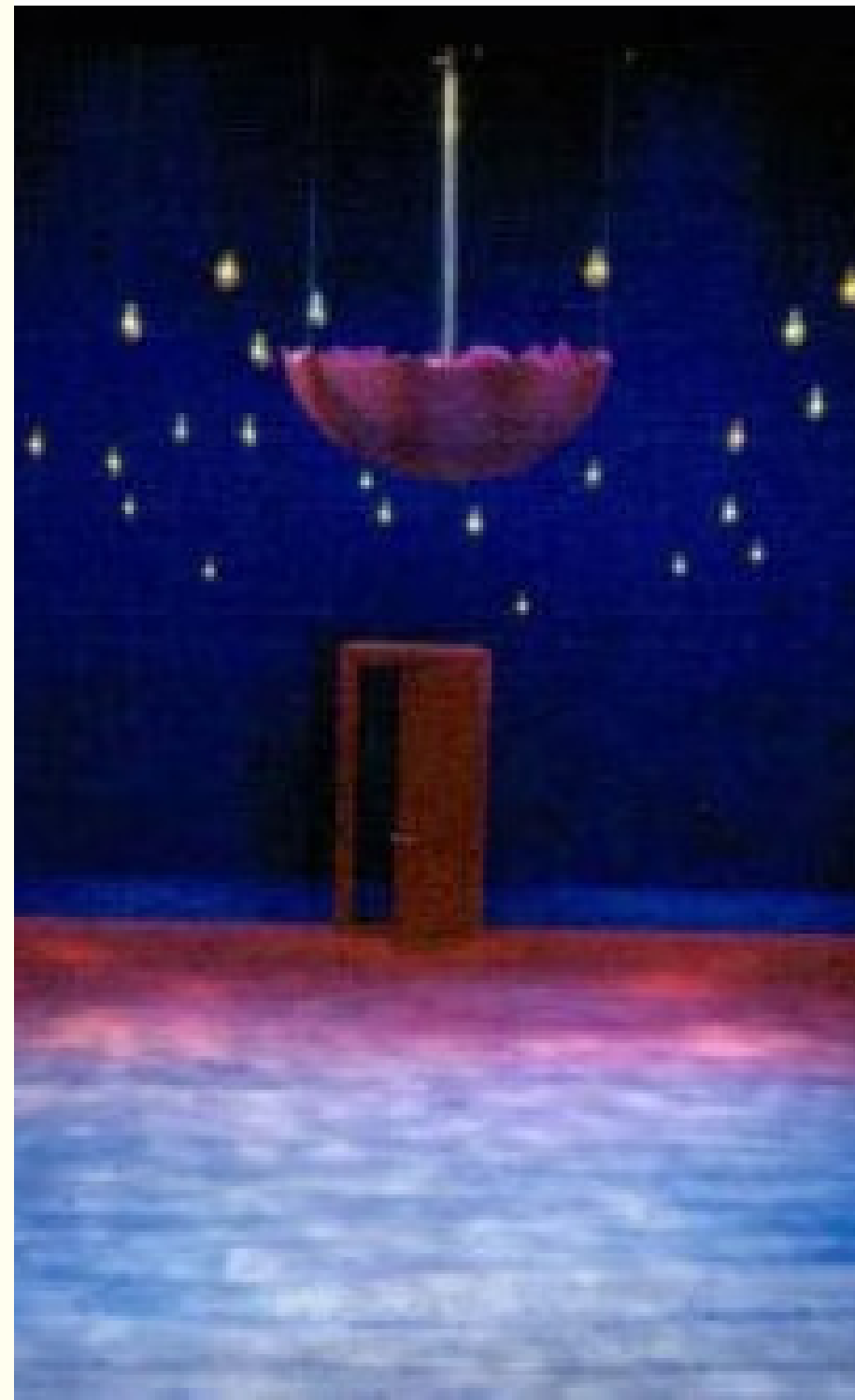
Theseus/Oberon and Hippolyta/Titania often played by the same actors, suggesting the fairy quarrel mirrors the court's tensions. Seen notably in the 1996 RSC production.

## Lights

The 1996 RSC production used hanging yellow light bulbs as the forest — "a kind of magic enlightenment" — and a giant umbrella for Titania's bower in honor of the bad weather prompted by the fairy royalty's spat.

## Costumes

Pajamas emphasize the dream quality and vulnerability of the lovers. Directors often have lovers slowly disrobe in the forest, "stripped to their basic psyches."



# Discussion Questions: Before & After the Play

## Love

Does love look "with the eyes, or with the mind"? Is love at first sight real — or just chemical? What happens when love changes?

## Comedy

How does the play divide and reunite its groups? Who is the "Lord of Misrule" subverting authority? Does "release" lead to "clarification"?

## Dream

Puck's epilogue says the audience "have but slumbered here." How does the play blur the line between dream and reality?

## Faerie

What does the presence of supernatural creatures offer — or threaten — for the mortals in the play? Do we believe in fairies?



# Puck's Epilogue: The Final Word

"If we shadows have offended,  
Think but this and all is mended,  
That you have but slumbered here  
While these visions did appear...  
So, good night unto you all.  
Give me your hands, if we be friends,  
And Robin shall restore amends."

- The epilogue frames the entire play as a dream — inviting the audience to forgive any offence as they would a strange night's sleep. An epilogue encourages applause — what other elements does this one engage?
- Both names — Puck (trickster) and Robin (helper) — appear in the epilogue: which side of him wins in the end?